stressed that it was a crucial part of the regeneration of Hindutva. The ceremony was conducted by the Akhil Bharatiya Vanvasi Kalyan Ashram (ABVKA), a Sangh Parivar outfit. Its activists had been working in the tribal districts of central India for over five decades. So crucial was Judeo's support to this work, which was clearly intended to counter Christian missionaries working in the same areas, that a month later, when he was ensnared in a sting operation that showed him accepting money over drinks and bad-mouthing Prime Minister Vajpayee, the RSS publicly defended him. Sangh leaders called the sting operation a 'Christian conspiracy'[4] during a campaign that the BJP and ABVKA framed as an electoral battle (against Congress's Ajit Jogi) between 'real' tribals and 'false' ones[5]. The BJP eventually won that election.[6]

I had met ABVKA workers a couple of years earlier in the remote villages of Gujarat's southern tribal district of Dang, where I was covering the aftermath of violence against Christian missionaries. There, I also spent time with the Christian missionaries from Kerala who were managing their parish from a colonial-era village church and running a Christian school in a village where many tribal houses now sported fluttering saffron flags. When Prime Minister Vajpayee visited Dang after the violence, he called for a 'national debate' on conversion.[7] In Gujarat, ABVKA was a relatively recent entrant at the time, but it had already altered social dynamics in the tribal villages. In Jashpur, on the other hand, it had been working continuously at least since 1952. In fact, it was here that ABVKA was born.

Surprisingly, the genesis of ABVKA was an initiative by the then Congress chief minister of Madhya Pradesh, Pandit Ravishankar Shukla, a Hindu traditionalist, to counter Christian missionaries. Founded by Ramakant Keshav Deshpande, its work was initially funded by the Jashpur royal court and Dilip Singh Judeo's grandfather, Vijay Bhushan Singh Deo. At the time, I did not know that the BJP candidate I was travelling with was continuing a royal family legacy that dated back to independent India's founding moment. Dilip Singh Judeo, who first became a BJP MP in 1989 and